

On X, users can disable discovery by email address or phone number, turn off address-book syncing and remove previously uploaded contacts. Contact syncing can otherwise influence account suggestions.

Instagram also lets users control account visibility, who may mention or tag them and whether contacts are connected for recommendations. A private account limits ordinary post visibility to approved followers, but approved followers can still copy, screenshot or redistribute material.

Examine the photograph, not just the face

Before posting, inspect every visible detail. Look for:

- house numbers and street signs;
- vehicle registrations;
- employee badges and school uniforms;
- delivery labels and boarding passes;
- reflections in windows, mirrors or spectacles;
- computer screens, calendars and paperwork;
- recognisable buildings outside a window;
- children's names, schedules or institutions.

Crop or blur sensitive details using a copy of the photograph. Keep the original separately when necessary. Do not assume a platform will remove every piece of metadata.



Photographs can contain location information. On an iPhone or iPad, Apple allows users to open a photograph, choose Adjust Location, and select No Location. Google Photos can display, edit or remove supported location information and lets users control whether location details are included in certain sharing contexts.

Metadata removal is only half the task. A photograph without GPS coordinates may still show a local shop, apartment tower or distinctive landscape. Visual clues can identify a place more accurately than a caption.

Do not publish your routine in real time

Posting from a location announces both where you are and, sometimes, where you are not. Delay holiday, restaurant, airport and event posts until after leaving. Avoid repeatedly showing the same commute, gym time, dog-walking route or work schedule.

Disable automatic location sharing that you do not use. Google provides system controls for pausing Google Location Sharing, while Apple provides controls for stopping location sharing with individuals or everyone. These settings differ from location embedded in photographs.

Friends can undermine careful settings by tagging you, naming the location or uploading a group photograph. Ask close contacts not to post your live location, home exterior, children's school information or travel plans without permission. Review tags and mentions rather than allowing them to appear automatically.

Step-by-step: publish a safer post

1. **Choose the identity.** Confirm that the account belongs to the correct personal, professional or pseudonymous compartment.
2. **Delay the upload.** Post after leaving when the image reveals a live location.
3. **Inspect the background.** Zoom into labels, reflections, screens, badges, documents and landmarks.
4. **Check location data.** Remove unnecessary GPS information from the sharing copy.
5. **Rewrite the caption.** Delete precise routines, dates, addresses and family details.
6. **Review the audience.** Check whether the account and post are public, follower-only or limited to a smaller group.
7. **Control tags.** Restrict who can mention or tag the account and review existing tags.
8. **Test as a stranger.** Open the profile while signed out or from an unrelated account.
9. **Search the username and image.** Look for links to older profiles or reused photographs.
10. **Recheck later.** Comments from friends may add identifying information after publication.

Perform the stranger test

Choose your public profile and spend ten minutes examining it as someone who dislikes you. Can you determine the city, employer, relatives, regular venues, travel dates or likely home area? Can a reused username lead to a forum account? Does the profile photograph appear elsewhere under your legal name?

Remove the most revealing connections first. Privacy does not require becoming uninteresting. It requires ensuring that a joke, photograph or professional update does not quietly become a map to your front door. **d**